

Consulting English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: management consultants, strategy consultants, implementation consultants, analysts, engagement managers, client partners, internal consultants, and advisory teams

Focus: A consulting English curriculum for discovery, hypotheses, stakeholder management, scope, executive recommendations, slide narratives, implementation risk, and client pushback.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Client Discovery and Problem Definition

Term	Working meaning
discovery	Working consulting term used in client discovery and problem definition; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
problem statement	Working consulting term used in client discovery and problem definition; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
decision question	Working consulting term used in client discovery and problem definition; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
stakeholder	Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

Hypotheses and Issue Trees

Term	Working meaning
hypothesis	Working consulting term used in hypotheses and issue trees; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
issue tree	Working consulting term used in hypotheses and issue trees; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
workstream	Working consulting term used in hypotheses and issue trees; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
evidence plan	Working consulting term used in hypotheses and issue trees; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Data Requests and Client Burden

Term	Working meaning
data request	Working consulting term used in data requests and client burden; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
confidentiality	Working consulting term used in data requests and client burden; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
owner	Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.
deadline	Working consulting term used in data requests and client burden; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis

Term	Working meaning
storyline	Working consulting term used in slide storylines and executive synthesis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
so what	Working consulting term used in slide storylines and executive synthesis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
recommendation	Working consulting term used in slide storylines and executive synthesis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Term	Working meaning
decision ask	Working consulting term used in slide storylines and executive synthesis; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Scope Management and Change Requests

Term	Working meaning
scope	Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.
change request	Working consulting term used in scope management and change requests; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
tradeoff	Working consulting term used in scope management and change requests; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
statement of work	Working consulting term used in scope management and change requests; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Difficult Client Feedback

Term	Working meaning
assumption	Working consulting term used in difficult client feedback; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
implementation constraint	Working consulting term used in difficult client feedback; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
stakeholder buy-in	Working consulting term used in difficult client feedback; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
iteration	Working consulting term used in difficult client feedback; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Implementation and Change Management

Term	Working meaning
operating model	How work is organized across people, process, technology, governance, and metrics.
change management	Working consulting term used in implementation and change management; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
adoption	Working consulting term used in implementation and change management; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
decision rights	Working consulting term used in implementation and change management; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Steering Committees and Final Readouts

Term	Working meaning
steering committee	Working consulting term used in steering committees and final readouts; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
option set	Working consulting term used in steering committees and final readouts; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.
risk	Working consulting term used in steering committees and final readouts; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Term	Working meaning
next step	Working consulting term used in steering committees and final readouts; define the owner, evidence source, governing document, risk, and decision impact before using it in a meeting.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Client Discovery and Problem Definition	Before we commit, I want to confirm discovery, problem statement, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If decision question, stakeholders, constraints, and expected use of analysis need clarification., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Hypotheses and Issue Trees	Before we commit, I want to confirm hypothesis, issue tree, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If hypotheses, issue tree, prioritization, and evidence plan should focus effort., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Data Requests and Client Burden	Before we commit, I want to confirm data request, confidentiality, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If data relevance, owner, confidentiality, deadline, and burden need management., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Slide Storylines and Executive Synthesis	Before we commit, I want to confirm storyline, so what, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If so-what, implication, recommendation, and decision ask must be explicit., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Scope Management and Change Requests	Before we commit, I want to confirm scope, change request, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scope, timeline, budget, value, and tradeoff need a formal conversation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Difficult Client Feedback	Before we commit, I want to confirm assumption, implementation constraint, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If implementation constraints, assumptions, and client knowledge should be integrated., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Implementation and Change Management	Before we commit, I want to confirm operating model, change management, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If change story, incentives, decision rights, training, and adoption metrics matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Steering Committees and Final Readouts	Before we commit, I want to confirm steering committee, option set, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If decision rights, options, risks, and next-step ownership need facilitation., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
discovery vs stakeholder	In client discovery and problem definition, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
hypothesis vs evidence plan	In hypotheses and issue trees, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
data request vs deadline	In data requests and client burden, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
storyline vs decision ask	In slide storylines and executive synthesis, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
scope vs statement of work	In scope management and change requests, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
assumption vs iteration	In difficult client feedback, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
operating model vs decision rights	In implementation and change management, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
steering committee vs next step	In steering committees and final readouts, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.